Pakistan factor, 3) China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), and 4) India’s relationship with the respective countries within the China–Russia–US triangle.

India’s position and motivation in joining the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

The SCO was originally created in the first years of the post–Cold War era to resolve China’s volatile border issues with the former Soviet republics.[4] China never placed India as part of the SCO framework, and China had already established a bilateral mechanism with India to deal with their boundary and trade issues. Over the years, China has rather successfully used the SCO as a platform to create a favourable atmosphere for itself. Compared to 15 or 20 years ago, China’s relations with Central Asian states have phenomenally transformed. It has persistently talked about deepening strategic cooperation and mutual trust. The consensus-based decisions in the SCO and the so-called “Shanghai spirit” serve China’s interests because of the strong bilateral economic ties it has maintained with other member states. Moreover, China’s approach has been to harmonise its policies with Russia’s regional agenda.

From India’s point of view, joining this China-led outfit made no sense if the China–Pakistan strategic nexus remained unaltered. Instead, joining the SCO would have provided Pakistan with yet another regional forum for mobilising support on the Kashmir issue with the tacit support of China. Also, in the absence of a direct land border with Central Asia, India’s ability to assert its interests in the SCO would have been rather meagre. Furthermore, the